

AND SO THE GREAT ONE CAME TO THE CITY OF APAMEA, ON THE EDGE OF THE SEA OF EPHIOS, AND THOUGH NO TEXT survives of what he said to the kings of this city, it is clear from secondhand sources that he brought his usual message: of co-option, of integration into their empire, and urgings of surrender. By now word had spread of his arrival in the region, and many were fearful—but the kings and wealthy landowners of Apamea refused him, and rudely rebuffed the great one. the great one did not respond with any wrath, as some had feared. Instead he simply walked to the city square, where he sat in the dust and began to build a cairn out of gray stones.

The legend goes that the great one built the cairn from noon to sunset, and the height of the construct grew to be extraordinary. Exact accounts differ regarding the height—some say a hundred feet tall, others hundreds of feet. However, every version of the story omits two critical parts: if the cairn of stones was extraordinarily tall, how did the great one, an average man in height, manage to keep stacking the stones on the top? It was said the great one could make many things float, and could fly himself—but this is not noted in this story. So—how?

And secondly, where did all these stones come from?

Regardless of the particulars, the great one began to build the cairn, and did not stop. And as night fell, and as they watched this curious display, the people of Apamea suddenly grew fearful, and left.

In the morning, when they returned to the city square, the great one was seated in the dust, still waiting patiently, and the cairn was gone—as were, the people later discovered, all the kings and wealthy landowners of Apamea, along with their families, old and young, and all their livestock, and the very buildings they'd lived and worked in. All had vanished overnight without a sound—perhaps taken to the place that the cairn had also gone.

The purpose of the cairn remains unknown, as does the final destination of those who resisted the great one in Apamea, who are still lost to history. Apamea, of course, no longer resisted the great one, and submitted to his rule—though it, like all of the lands of the Empire, was eventually totally destroyed. As is well documented, it is unknown if a civil war was the source of this conflict, or if, perhaps, they battled against another, greater force.

Such an idea troubles me—and yet, it must be considered.

— GIANCAMO ADORNI, DEPUTY OF THE HOUSE OF GUARCO, COLLECTED TALES OF THE EMPIRE

INFORMATION

Perform a DC 20 History Check to recall information on the city of Apamea.